

Summer language gains and community building at Boğaziçi University's Immersive Turkish Language and Culture Program

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Outline

- Structure of the Turkish Language and Culture Program (TLCP) at Boğaziçi University
- Relation with the American Research Institute (ARIT) in Turkey
- Language gains: students' test results on pre- and post-program proficiency tests
- Community building: student evaluations



Turkish Language and Culture Program at Boğaziçi University

- Annual intensive summer program; in effect since 1982
- 160 hours of instruction in in-person 8-week program, 80-120 in online (in 2021, during Covid)
- Classes offered in lower and upper intermediate, and advanced levels
- Classes with 5-10 students
- 40-50 students each year; undergraduate and graduate students from schools in the US and Europe

Turkish Language and Culture Program at Boğaziçi University

- Grammar, reading, writing and speaking classes & lab hours
- Classes taught by university staff specialized in teaching Turkish as a foreign language
- Four main exams (two proficiency tests, a midterm and a final exam), plus quizzes, assignments, presentations etc.
- First-hand experience with the Turkish culture through informal conversation hours, lectures, movies, excursions etc.

The American Research Institute in Turkey (ARIT)

a Council of American Overseas Research Centers (CAORC) member since 1981

The ARIT-Boğaziçi University Fellowship is a Fulbright-Hays Group Projects Abroad program sponsored by the US Department of Education. It has been in operation since 1984. Sylvia Önder has been Project Director since 2013. Since then, the program has supported

171 ARIT-BU Fellows from 60 institutions

Public Universities: 29

Private Universities: 30

Foreign Universities: 6 (3 in Türkiye)

Colleges: 4

Comparisons in the Methods of Teaching Turkish

Turkish at Boğaziçi's TLCP

- Each student has four faculty instructors and several graduate student TAs; the faculty are experts in linguistics and language pedagogy
- 12 credits, classes run from 9 am to 1 pm and afternoon lectures, films, trips, conversation hours happen almost daily during the week
- Materials prepared by the staff based on the needs of the students in each class, revised every year

Turkish in the USA

- Usually one single faculty teaching, sometimes FLTA or TAs, a few programs have more than one faculty, but each class is usually taught by only one for a semester or year; the faculty are often native speakers with no formal training in language pedagogy
- Mostly 3 or 4 credits per semester, usually not intensive, and extra events usually not required, only recommended
- Published books as course materials, sometimes accompanied by handouts

Participants of the Program

163 students from the years of 2019, 2021, 2022 and 2023

76 of them funded by ARIT

45 of them participated in the online format in 2021

	<i>N</i> of students
Lower intermediate	30
Upper intermediate	35
Lower advanced	34
Upper advanced; reading oriented	32
Upper advanced; speaking oriented	32

TLCP's Pre- and Post-Program Tests

- Turkish proficiency test in the format of international language exams, e.g., IELTS and TOEFL
- Taken fully online, lasts 3 hours
- Taken twice by each student; at the beginning and end of the program
- An online system has been developed using the Python-based web framework Django
 - Exam interface designed based on prominent international language exams
 - Design choices guided by the characteristics of the target users, aiming to minimize stress and distractions for students (Mejía et al., 2012; Rellon et al., 2012; Stowell & Bennett, 2010)
 - Norman's (1998) Human Computer Interaction principles, e.g., simple task structure, visibility.
 - 2 modules: exam interface for students and admin panel for instructors

TLCP's pre- and post-program tests

Includes four parts:

1. **Grammar:** 20 multiple-choice questions, 5 sentence-cloze tests (25 points)
2. **Reading:** three reading texts in varying length, with questions in different formats such as multiple choice, vocab cloze test, matching topic sentences with paragraphs (30 points)
3. **Writing:** one short essay to report results for a visual graphic (75 words), one long essay on a discussion topic (150 words), averaged scores by two graders (25 points)
4. **Speaking:** 15-min interviews with two instructors, one picture depiction task and one discussion question, averaged scores from two instructors (20 points)

ARIT's pre- and post-program tests

Pre-Program Testing Includes four parts, three of which have been included here

- 1) A reading comprehension test and composition (used for selection purposes, not included here)
- 2) A telephone interview by teachers trained in the ACFTL guidelines
- 3) An Online Listening Test, run by Brigham Young University, designed by AATT
- 4) An Online Reading Test, run by Brigham Young University, designed by AATT

Post-Program Testing includes three parts

- 1) An oral interview along ACFTL guidelines
- 2) An Online Listening Test, run by Brigham Young University, designed by AATT
- 3) An Online Reading Test, run by Brigham Young University, designed by AATT

All parts were separately graded as Novice, Low, Medium, High; Intermediate Low, Medium, High; Advanced, Low, Medium, High, and Superior.

Language gains

We compared students' scores on the pre- and post-program proficiency tests of TLCP.

Paired samples t-tests showed that students' grammar, writing, speaking and total scores increased in the post-program test.

TLCP's tests	Pre-program test	Post-program test	<i>t</i> value	<i>p</i> value
Grammar	14.39 (4.77)	17.95 (5.11)	$t(150) = 9.13$	$p < .001^*$
Reading	15.8 (6.6)	16.29 (6.11)	$t(150) = .11$	$p = .92$
Writing	14.58 (5.94)	17.17 (6.07)	$t(144) = 5.23$	$p < .001^*$
Speaking	10.65 (4.88)	13.3 (4.17)	$t(153) = 8.04$	$p < .001^*$
Total	52.56 (18.96)	62.53 (20.52)	$t(155) = 7.69$	$p < .001^*$

The table shows mean and standard deviation (in parentheses) of the scores. The *p* values with a **** are significant after Bonferroni correction.

Language gains

76 of the students were funded by ARIT; and took ARIT's as well as TLCP's tests.

ARIT's letter grades were converted into scores between 1 and 4:

1.25 (Novice-Low), 1.5 (Novice-Mid), 1.75 (Novice-High) ... 4 (Superior)

Paired samples t-tests showed students' reading, listening and total scores increased in the post-test.

ARIT's tests	Pre-program test	Post-program test	<i>t</i> value	<i>p</i> value
Reading	2.81 (.91)	3.21 (.8)	$t(72) = 3.89$	$p < .001^*$
Listening	2.07 (.52)	2.35 (.62)	$t(71) = 4.72$	$p < .001^*$
Speaking	2.9 (.45)	3.01 (.6)	$t(73) = 1.61$	$p = .11$
Total	7.48 (2.06)	8.13 (2.29)	$t(76) = 4.19$	$p < .001^*$

The table shows mean and standard deviation (in parentheses) of the scores. The *p* values with a ^{**} are significant after Bonferroni correction.

Comparing TLCP's and ARIT's tests

76 students took both TLCP's and ARIT's tests.

These students' scores in TLCP and ARIT tests were compared to check whether the two tests are comparable. ARIT's total scores that were out of 12 were scaled to 100.

Paired samples t-tests showed that students' scores were similar in TLCP and ARIT tests.

	TLCP's test	ARIT's test	<i>t</i> value	<i>p</i> value
Pre-program	60.92 (15.92)	62.03 (17.1)	$t(74) = .67$	$p = .51$
Post-program	67.9 (18.7)	67.52 (19.06)	$t(71) = .14$	$p = .89$

The table shows mean and standard deviation (in parentheses) of the scores.

Comparing online and in-person program

In the summer of 2021, 45 students participated in the online version of the program. In the online program there were 80 or 120 contact hours (vs. 160 in in-person).

Improvement in online and in-person programs were compared with scores in pre- and post-program tests. Improvement scores were created by subtracting the total pre-program scores from the total post-program scores.

Independent samples t-tests showed that students who did the in-person program improved more than those who did the online program according to TLCP's tests, but not ARIT's tests.

	In-person	Online	<i>t</i> value	<i>p</i> value
Improvement in TLCP's tests	13.67 (13.7)	-.82 (15.35)	$t(71) = 5.47$	$p < .001^*$
Improvement in ARIT's tests	5.54 (11.95)	5.83 (11.15)	$t(65) = .11$	$p = .91$

The table shows mean and standard deviation (in parentheses) of the difference between pre- and post-program test scores. The *p* values with a '*' are significant.

Language gains across different levels

Improvement scores were created for each level.

Independent samples t-tests showed that all levels improved similarly in both TLCP's and ARIT's tests (p 's > .5).

	Improvement in TLCP's tests	Improvement in ARIT's tests
Lower intermediate	11.1 (18.7)	13.9 (12.2)
Upper intermediate	10.8 (16.4)	9.03 (10.6)
Lower advanced	10.8 (11.1)	6.58 (10.4)
Upper advanced; reading oriented	9.28 (12.2)	6.02 (10.4)
Upper advanced; speaking oriented	5.87 (19.2)	6.52 (13)

The table shows mean and standard deviation (in parentheses) of the difference between pre- and post-program test scores.

Summary: Language gains

- Students improved in most of the skills that were tested
 - Reading scores did not improve in TLCP tests
 - Reading comprises many subskills and cognitive abilities. Multiple choice and matching questions may not have targeted reading abilities that improved. Different tasks such as cloze task or summarizing may be included in the tests (Grabe & Jiang, 2013).
 - Speaking scores didn't improve in ARIT tests: Different raters for pre- and post-program tests, post-program rater may be more demanding
- Students at all levels improved to a similar degree

Summary: Language gains

- Some evidence for increased improvement in in-person compared to online format
 - Due to fewer contact hours (80/120 vs. 160 in in-person)
 - Students' foreign language enjoyment drops in online compared to classroom formats (e.g., Resnik, Dewaele, & Knechtelsdorfer, 2023)
- TLCP's and ARIT's tests, although in different formats, are comparable
 - TLCP's tests don't have listening
 - ARIT's tests don't have grammar and writing
- Language skills represent both a prominent *general language ability* that is common to all domains, as well as *specific abilities* that are unique to each of the four domains (Sawaki, Stricker, & Oranje, 2008).
- A single test that includes all four skills

Student Evaluations: Building Community?

“The framework of the program was welcoming and immersive but recognized that its students have lives outside the program, both in Istanbul and more broadly. A lot of intensive programs either don’t allow for that, on one hand, or aren’t actually intensive, on the other.”

“Some of the classes were very productive, and the social environment was really enjoyable. I would provide the warning that it is a significant time and energy commitment beyond the 9 am-1 pm classes, and that they should plan to not be able to do other work or research during the duration of the program.”

Student Evaluations:

“Would you recommend the program?”

“Yes, absolutely. TLCP is the best Turkish learning experience I have ever had. I felt that the program was really well-structured, and it really felt like the instructors were experts in their field. The collegial atmosphere (even though everything was online) with the other fellows also greatly enriched my experience.”

“Yes, I would strongly recommend the TLCP to anyone who is serious about learning Turkish. In my five years of studying Turkish, I found that the TLCP is the most systematic, comprehensive instruction available – more so than the courses I took at my university. I feel that my Turkish is better now than it was after a year of living and working in Turkey.”

Student Evaluations: Online in 2021 and Partially Hybrid in 2022

“If virtual again, then No from me personally just because language classes on Zoom are really difficult for me. I had trouble staying engaged in a different language for so long and so early in the morning with the time difference. If it were in person, then Yes because the instructors and material were great, and I feel that my language skills definitely improved.”

“Well, quarantining was not fun. The TLCP people was [sic] able to give us the option to attend online but the classes are really structured to be given in person so it sucked to be online even though the online option was great in terms of not missing a class.”

Community Building in Study Abroad

“I can't say enough about TA's. They are energetic, understanding, kind, open minded, and super friendly. I was able to talk and hang out with most of them, they are wonderful and bright people.”

“N is an excellent TA as well, specially he was very successful in building a learning community around the program.”

“R is an excellent TA. She was so supportive, and ready to help at any time. She is passionate and talented student with excellent skills of teaching.”

“I really enjoyed the outside-the-classroom activities. They were very good ways to connect with my classmates while also practicing my Turkish in a natural manner.”

Conclusions and Directions for Future Research

- TLCP's test is, to our knowledge, the only **online** proficiency test delivered in a Türkiye-based institution
- We are considering the benefits of unifying the tests delivered by TLCP and ARIT and create a single proficiency test including all four skills
 - to decrease the number of tests that ARIT fellows take
 - to create an online Turkish proficiency test that can be taken by all Turkish learners worldwide
 - to offer a certificate prepared in accordance with the definitions of proficiency set in the text of the Common European Framework of Reference for Language Teaching, e.g., A1 to C2 levels

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